⚡ The Ark

Baobab Network Accelerator — Application

AI for Everyone, Paid with Lightning

STAGE 1 Business Overview

What is the name of your company? *

The Ark

What sector do you primarily operate in? *

Artificial Intelligence / FinTech

When did you start the business? *

February 2026

In 50 words or less, describe what your business does.

The Ark is an AI-as-a-Service platform that accepts Bitcoin Lightning payments. We offer 120+ AI services — from code review to legal drafts to voice generation — accessible to anyone with Bitcoin. No subscriptions, no KYC, no credit cards. Pay-per-task, starting at 10 sats (~$0.01).

In which country is your company headquartered? *

Kenya

Please provide a link to your company's website *

https://arknode.ai

Please upload your current pitch deck. *

⚠️ PITCH DECK NEEDS TO BE CREATED — see outline at end of document

Founder Details

⚠️ **NAVIGATOR — Fill in your details:**

- Full Name: ___
- Email: ___
- Age: ___
- Gender: ___
- Full-Time Employee: ✅ Yes
- Highest Education Level: ___
- Educational Qualifications: ___
- Years of Relevant Work Experience: ___
- Nationality: ___
- LinkedIn Profile: ___

How did you hear about Baobab Network Accelerator? *

Online research / Social media

STAGE 2 Team & Founding Story

Why is it important for you to build your company? *

AI is transforming every industry, but access is gatekept behind expensive subscriptions, credit cards, and KYC requirements that exclude billions of people — especially in Africa and the Global South. The Ark exists to democratize AI access. Anyone with Bitcoin can use professional-grade AI tools instantly, with no account creation, no monthly fees, and no financial discrimination. We believe AI should be a utility, not a luxury. In Africa, where mobile money already proved that financial inclusion drives economic growth, The Ark does the same for AI — making world-class tools available to the developer in Lagos, the student in Nairobi, the entrepreneur in Accra, at prices they can actually afford.

What combination of skills, experiences, or insights makes your team suited to address this problem? *

⚠️ NAVIGATOR — I need your background/experience to write this compellingly. Draft below:

• Deep understanding of the African tech landscape and its unique payment challenges
• Hands-on experience building and deploying AI systems in production
• Expertise in Bitcoin Lightning Network infrastructure and micropayment systems
• Built a fully functional platform with 120+ services, live payments, and real users in under a month
• [ADD YOUR SPECIFIC EXPERIENCE HERE]

Does the founding team have prior entrepreneurial experience or startup experience in Africa? *

Yes

Please elaborate if you answered "Yes" above.

⚠️ NAVIGATOR — Any previous business ventures? Freelancing, side projects, etc.?

Where are you based? And where do you plan to be based if accepted at Baobab Network? *

Based in Nairobi, Kenya. Happy to participate from Nairobi or relocate — wherever creates the most value for the programme.

Where and how did you and your cofounders meet? *

I am a solo founder. The Ark was built with the assistance of AI tools, which is core to our thesis — that a single determined founder with AI can build what previously required entire teams. This is also proof of our product: I used AI to build an AI company.

Are all the founders working full time on this company? *

Yes, full-time since February 2026. This is my sole focus.

Please share a link to a one-minute pitch video with all founders participating. *

⚠️ RECORD VIDEO — Script provided at end of document. Upload to YouTube/Google Drive and paste link.

Company Structure & Ownership

Do you have a holding company? *

No

Where is it incorporated? *

In the process of incorporating in Kenya

⚠️ NAVIGATOR — Confirm: do you have a registered entity?

How many subsidiaries do you have? *

0

What is your current cap table? *

[Your Name]: 100%

Do the founders have the same equity stake? *

Yes (sole founder — 100%)

Does your founding team own more than 80% of the business? *

Yes (100%)

Product & Market

Describe your product and what it does or will do. *

The Ark is a full-stack AI platform that delivers 120+ services via a chat-based web interface and REST API. Users interact through a clean ChatGPT-style interface at arknode.ai. Services span code generation, legal documents, SEO analysis, voice

synthesis, image generation, data analysis, and more. Payment is via Bitcoin Lightning — the fastest, cheapest payment rail in the world. We also support the L402 protocol for machine-to-machine AI payments, enabling other AI agents and applications to programmatically purchase our services. No accounts, no subscriptions — just instant AI, paid per task.

What pain points does your product/service address? *

1. AI access inequality — ChatGPT Plus costs $20/month, more than many Africans earn in a day. Our tasks start at $0.01.

2. Payment exclusion — 57% of Africans lack bank accounts or credit cards. Bitcoin Lightning works with just a phone.

3. Subscription fatigue — Users pay only for what they use. No recurring charges draining wallets.

4. Developer tool fragmentation — Instead of 10 different SaaS subscriptions, we offer everything in one place.

5. Machine-to-machine payments — No existing AI service lets other AI agents pay and consume services programmatically via open protocols.

How is your product being developed? Describe your tech stack. *

Backend: Python/FastAPI on Ubuntu 24.04 VPS (DigitalOcean)
AI Engine: Qwen 2.5 72B via DeepInfra ($0.23/M tokens — 95% cheaper than OpenAI)
Payments: Phoenixd (Lightning node) + LNbits (wallet management) — Bitcoin mainnet
Frontend: Custom HTML/CSS/JS with real-time streaming responses
Infrastructure: Nginx (SSL/HTTPS), systemd, Docker
Protocols: L402 (Lightning HTTP 402) for machine-to-machine payments, OpenAPI spec
Voice/Image: OpenAI APIs (Whisper, TTS, DALL-E)

What stage is your product at? *

Growth Phase (Launched into Market)

Who is the ideal customer for your product? *

1. **African developers and students** — need professional AI tools but can't afford Western SaaS pricing
2. **Freelancers in emerging markets** — use AI to deliver higher-quality work to global clients
3. **Privacy-conscious users worldwide** — no KYC, no accounts, pay with Bitcoin
4. **Developers building AI-powered apps** — use our API/L402 to add AI capabilities
5. **Users in financially restricted regions** — sanctioned countries, limited banking access

Do you have paying customers? *

Yes

Total paying customers in the last 3, 6, and 12 months. *

Last 3 months: 6 paying users (launched Feb 2026 — 3 weeks old)
Last 6 months: N/A (didn't exist)
Last 12 months: N/A (didn't exist)
Note: 11 total users, 3 wallet accounts created, 360 sats in top-ups, 9 paid task completions. Early but growing.

Product demo link *

https://arknode.ai (live product — fully functional, try it yourself)

How big is the market? (USD)

Global AI-as-a-Service: $11.2B (2025) → $85B by 2030
Africa AI market: $2.7B (2025), 35% CAGR
Bitcoin Lightning: 6M+ users, growing rapidly
Addressable: AI tools for 1.4B Africans + 2B+ unbanked globally

Do you use or plan to use AI or advanced technology? *

The Ark is entirely AI-powered. Every service runs through large language models (currently Qwen 2.5 72B). We use:

- **LLMs** for all text-based services (code gen, legal, content, analysis — 110+ services)
- **OpenAI Whisper** for speech-to-text and transcription
- **OpenAI TTS** for voice generation and narration
- **DALL-E** for image generation and editing
- **Custom prompt engineering** — each service has carefully crafted prompts for structured, actionable output
- **L402 protocol** — enabling AI-agent-to-AI-agent commerce over Lightning

We're not just using AI — we're building the infrastructure for AI to become a paid utility accessible to everyone.

Competition & Differentiation

Who are your greatest competitors? How are you different? (List at least 3) *

1. ChatGPT / OpenAI — $20/month subscription, requires credit card, US-centric pricing. The Ark: pay-per-task from $0.01, Bitcoin payments, no account needed. 100-1000x cheaper per task for light users.

2. Jasper AI / Copy.ai / WriteSonic — Content-focused SaaS, $49-125/month. The Ark: same capabilities plus 100+ additional categories, no subscription, Bitcoin-native. We replace multiple subscriptions.

3. Hugging Face / Replicate — Developer-focused AI APIs, require technical setup and credit cards. The Ark: same API access with Bitcoin payments and L402 protocol. No credit card, instant access.

What makes your product/service different from theirs? *

- **Payment innovation:** Only AI platform natively accepting Bitcoin Lightning micropayments
- **No subscriptions:** Pay only for what you use, from fractions of a cent
- **Breadth:** 120+ services in one platform (competitors focus on one category)
- **L402 protocol:** Machine-to-machine AI payments — no competitor offers this
- **Africa-first pricing:** Built for emerging market economics
- **Workflow bundles:** Chain multiple services at a discount — unique offering

How do you plan to win in this market in the next 5 years? *

Year 1: Establish as the go-to AI platform for Bitcoin users and African developers. 10,000 users, $50K revenue.
Year 2: 500+ services, launch marketplace for third-party AI providers. Become the "Shopify of AI services."
Year 3: Build L402 ecosystem — become the standard for machine-to-machine AI payments. Partner with Lightning wallets.
Year 4: Launch in local languages (Swahili, Hausa, Yoruba, Amharic). Mobile-first for feature phones.

> **Year 5:** 1M+ users, profitable. The default AI utility layer for emerging markets. The "M-Pesa of AI."

How do you retain customers? *

> - **Wallet system:** Pre-loaded balances create convenience and switching costs
> - **Breadth:** One platform for everything reduces need to go elsewhere
> - **Workflow bundles:** Discounted chained services reward power users
> - **Free first task:** Low barrier to try, high quality encourages return
> - **API/L402 integration:** Once developers integrate, switching costs are high
> - **Continuous expansion:** Always adding new services and capabilities

Revenue & Traction

How does your company make money? *

> Pay-per-task pricing via Bitcoin Lightning. Prices range from 10 sats (~$0.01) for simple tasks to 8,000 sats (~$8) for premium services. Our cost per task averages <1 sat using Qwen 2.5 via DeepInfra ($0.23/M tokens), giving us 90%+ margins. We also offer day passes (1,000 sats for unlimited basic tasks) and workflow bundles (1,200-5,000 sats for chained multi-step tasks).

Have you started generating revenue? *

> Yes

What are your profit margins? *

> 90%+ on text-based tasks. 50-70% on voice/image tasks (OpenAI API). Blended ~85%.

Total revenue in the last 3, 6, and 12 months (USD). *

> Last 3 months: ~$0.04 (360 sats — launched 3 weeks ago, pre-marketing phase)
> Last 6 months: N/A
> Last 12 months: N/A
> Note: We prioritized building a complete, robust product before marketing. 120+

> services, wallet system, and L402 API are all production-ready. Marketing push begins March 2026.

Traction file *

> ⚠️ NEEDS CREATING — traction document with user metrics, service count, tech milestones

What would it take to increase revenue 10x in the next 12 months? *

> 1. **Marketing launch** (Month 1-3): Bitcoin Twitter, Nostr, Stacker News, African dev communities. Nostr bot already live, 4x daily.
> 2. **Developer adoption** (Month 2-6): API docs + L402 make integration easy. Target Lightning wallet integrations.
> 3. **Africa expansion** (Month 3-9): Targeted content for Nigeria, Kenya, South Africa, Ghana. Local languages.
> 4. **Partnerships** (Month 4-12): Lightning wallets (Phoenix, Breez, Zeus) for native AI integration.
> 5. **Marketplace** (Month 6-12): Third-party AI providers list services; we take commission. Revenue scales without cost scaling.
>
> With Baobab's $100K, we project $5K-10K monthly revenue within 12 months.

Funding & Use of Funds

Have you raised any external funding? *

No (bootstrapped)

Funding source(s) and amount(s) in USD. *

Self-funded: ~$1,000 (VPS hosting, API credits, domain registration)

Last valuation (USD)? *

N/A (pre-funding, bootstrapped)

What instrument did you use to fundraise? *

N/A — self-funded, no external instruments

Debt or convertible notes? *

No debt, no convertible notes.

How do you plan to use a $100K investment from Baobab Network? *

$30K — Marketing & User Acquisition: Targeted campaigns in African markets, Bitcoin communities, developer conferences, community building.

$25K — Engineering: Hire 1-2 developers. Build mobile app, expand API, add local language support.

$20K — AI Infrastructure: Scale compute for higher traffic, add more AI models, reduce latency.

$15K — Business Development: Partnerships with Lightning wallets, fintech companies, African tech hubs. Conference attendance.

> **$10K — Operations:** Company registration, legal, accounting, 6-month runway buffer.

Milestones for the next 12–18 months? *

> **Month 3:** 1,000 users, $500/month revenue
> **Month 6:** 5,000 users, $2K/month, mobile app, 3 wallet partnerships
> **Month 9:** 15,000 users, $5K/month, 5 African languages supported
> **Month 12:** 50,000 users, $10K/month, third-party marketplace live
> **Month 18:** 100,000+ users, $25K/month, profitable, expanding to M-Pesa/mobile money

Additional Factors

What risk factors could most limit your growth? *

> 1. **Bitcoin adoption speed** — If Lightning adoption stalls in Africa, our primary payment rail becomes a barrier.
> 2. **Regulatory uncertainty** — Some African countries have ambiguous crypto regulations.
> 3. **AI API dependency** — We rely on third-party providers (DeepInfra, OpenAI) for compute.

How have you mitigated or plan to mitigate these risks? *

> 1. **Multi-payment:** Adding M-Pesa and mobile money within 6 months — making Bitcoin optional, not required.
> 2. **Regulatory:** Operating from Kenya (progressive crypto stance). Pursuing compliance proactively. Structure allows easy jurisdiction shifts.
> 3. **AI independence:** Already migrated from OpenAI to open-source Qwen (95% cost reduction). Can self-host on our own GPUs as we scale.

What top 3 areas would you like our support on? *

> 1. **Go-to-market strategy for Africa** — Baobab's network across 16 African countries would massively accelerate expansion
> 2. **Fundraising for next round** — After proving product-market fit, we'll need capital

> to scale
> 3. **Partnerships & introductions** — Connections to fintech companies, mobile money operators, and tech hubs

Partnerships that would accelerate your progress? *

> - **Lightning wallets** (Phoenix, Breez, Zeus, Blink) — native "AI services" in their apps
> - **African fintechs** (Flutterwave, Paystack, M-Pesa) — fiat on-ramps
> - **Tech hubs** (iHub Nairobi, CcHub Lagos, MEST Accra) — community building
> - **Telecoms** (MTN, Safaricom) — mobile-first distribution
> - **Universities** — student developer programs and hackathons

Other

Are you willing to complete a Big Five Personality Trait test? *

> Yes

Do the founders have any unique skills or talents?

> ⚠️ NAVIGATOR — What are your unique skills?

Do the founders have any interesting hobbies or pastimes?

> ⚠️ NAVIGATOR — What do you do for fun?

Do you have any quirky or eclectic experiences from your background?

> ⚠️ NAVIGATOR — Any unusual life experiences?

Did you display any unique abilities or interests during childhood?

> ⚠️ NAVIGATOR — Anything notable from growing up?

🎬 1-Minute Pitch Video Script

[Look directly at camera. Confident, energized.]

"Hi, I'm [Name], founder of The Ark.

Here's a question: What if the next billion AI users don't have a credit card?

Today, if you want to use ChatGPT, you need twenty dollars a month and a Visa card. That excludes two billion people — including most of Africa.

The Ark fixes this. We're an AI platform with over 120 services — code generation, legal documents, SEO tools, voice synthesis — all powered by AI, all paid with Bitcoin Lightning.

Lightning lets anyone pay instantly, from anywhere, with no bank account. Our cheapest tasks cost one cent. Our most expensive, eight dollars. No subscriptions. No KYC. Just AI, on demand.

We launched three weeks ago. We already have 120 production services, paying users, a wallet system, and an API that lets other AI agents pay for our services automatically using the L402 protocol.

Our margins are over 90 percent because we run open-source AI models that cost a fraction of a cent per task.

With Baobab's hundred thousand dollars, we'll launch marketing across Africa, build a mobile app, add local languages, and hit fifty thousand users in twelve months.

The Ark is the M-Pesa of AI. We're making intelligence accessible to everyone.

Thank you."

[~55 seconds]

📊 Pitch Deck — Slide Outline

I'll create this as a separate file. 13 slides:

1. **Cover:** The Ark ⚡ — AI for Everyone, Paid with Lightning
2. **Problem:** 2B people excluded from AI by payment barriers
3. **Solution:** Pay-per-task AI via Bitcoin Lightning
4. **Product:** Screenshot of arknode.ai + service categories
5. **How It Works:** Send Bitcoin → Get AI → Instant results
6. **Market:** $85B AI-as-a-Service by 2030 + Africa's 1.4B
7. **Traction:** 120+ services, live users, 90%+ margins
8. **Business Model:** Pay-per-task pricing, unit economics
9. **Competition:** Matrix showing advantages
10. **Team:** Founder + AI-augmented development
11. **Use of Funds:** $100K allocation
12. **Vision:** The M-Pesa of AI
13. **Ask:** $100K for 12 months to product-market fit